

Updated: Less driving is possible

Residents of several states have driven fewer miles on average in recent years than they did three decades ago. This decline suggests that Americans' high levels of driving are not inevitable.

BIKING, WALKING & TRANSIT

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For many decades after the introduction of the automobile, Americans drove more miles every year. The increase in driving was facilitated by a transportation system that [made it easy](#) to drive more, resulting in increased [air and climate pollution](#) and rampant [sprawl](#), while giving

Americans little choice but to [spend their limited household incomes](#) on cars.

However, residents in several states have broken with this decades-long trend and have driven fewer miles on average in recent years. A mix of reasons may have caused driving to decline. One factor is a growing population in compact neighborhoods where residents don't need to drive as far or as often. Another factor is demographic change, such as an aging population and a larger population engaged in remote work. A third contributing factor may be investments in infrastructure that support walking, biking or riding transit, allowing residents to drive less.

Whatever the cause, the decline in per-capita driving in a few leading states suggests that Americans' current levels of car travel are not inevitable. Travel habits can change, leaving us with less pollution, safer and more pleasant communities, and, often, more choices than before.

Miles driven per person

Driving is measured in terms of "vehicle miles traveled," or VMT – the total number of miles driven in all kinds of cars, trucks, buses and other vehicles. To compare how much people in different states drive, it is more useful to look at VMT per capita, the number of miles driven by each person.

Per capita VMT varies tremendously from one state to another, influenced by development patterns, geographic elements, the availability of walking, biking, and transit options, the age of the population, and other factors. Per capita VMT in 2024 was lowest in New York, Rhode Island, Pennsylvania and Hawaii, ranging from 6,000 to nearly 7,500 miles per person. The state with the most driving on a per capita basis in 2024 was Wyoming, with just under 16,600 miles per person, followed by Alabama, Mississippi and New Mexico. Figure 1 shows per capita VMT for each state in 2024.* (In 2019, before the pandemic, per capita VMT in most states was slightly higher.)

Figure 1. VMT per capita by state, 2024



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Change in miles driven per person

To understand how driving patterns have changed over time, we can look at the change in VMT per capita over decades. Figure 2 reveals large variations between states. Over the 30-year period from 1994 to 2024, per capita VMT declined in 10 states and increased in the other 40. Washington, D.C., showed a decline as well.

Figure 2. Change in per capita VMT by state, 1994-2024



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Miles driven per person has fallen the most in Washington state

VMT per capita has fallen more in Washington than in any other state over the last 30 years. Contributing factors in this decline include the state's decades-long program to reduce drive-alone trips to work, as well as reduced driving in Seattle, the state's largest city.

In 1994, Washington ranked 35th overall for per capita VMT, with residents driving an average of nearly 9,000 miles per year. By 2024, per capita VMT in Washington had dropped to 7,638 miles per year, and the state was ranked 45th for per capita driving. In 2024, the average Washington resident drove 1,186 *fewer* miles annually compared to 1994. In contrast, the average American drove an *additional* 1,281 miles in 2024 compared to 1994. (See Figure 3.) In 2019, the year before the pandemic, the average Washington resident drove 613 fewer miles compared to 1994, while the average American drove about 1,000 more miles compared to 1994.

Figure 3. Per capita VMT in Washington state, 1981 to 2024



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One reason that VMT has fallen more in Washington than in other states may lie in Washington's efforts to reduce the number of people who drive alone to work. Washington adopted a commute-trip reduction law in 1991 that requires worksites with [100 or more full-time employees](#) who must start their work day between 6 and 9 a.m. to provide employees with [tools and incentives](#) to help make it easier for them to get to work without driving, or to work from home. The law has significantly reduced drive-alone commuting. Approximately [half](#) of the 600,000 employees who are covered by the Commute Trip Reduction Program drove alone to work in 2023/2024, versus 65% for other Washington employees. Nationally, 69% of employees drove to work alone.

Another reason for the decline in per capita VMT in Washington is that per capita VMT in Seattle, the state's largest city, has declined.

Seattle's per capita VMT has fallen for nearly two decades, dropping from approximately [7,400 miles per resident in 2005](#) to [6,150 miles in 2018](#), and even further to around [5,500 miles in 2022](#). (Total VMT in that period increased, however, because the city's population increased more rapidly than per capita VMT declined. Had these new residents not moved to Seattle, however, they may have lived in areas that required more driving.)

[Few](#) people who work in Seattle drive to work alone. Before the COVID-19 pandemic, fewer and fewer workers in Seattle commuted to work alone by car. In 2024, [31% of workers](#) in Seattle drove to work alone, down from [35% in 2009](#). The drive-alone rate has actually increased since 2022, which is likely due to people returning to offices.

However, commuting trips represent only a fraction of the total trips that Seattle residents take, and most non-work trips still involve driving alone. [More than 70%](#) of grocery store and school pick-up and drop-off trips are completed by driving alone.

Several investments have helped Seattle achieve relatively low rates of car-based commuting and provide residents with more options for non-work trips.

- Seattle-area voters approved funding in 1996 to create a regional transit system, and additional funding in 2008 to [add 36 miles of light rail](#). Another voter-approved funding measure has enabled the system to continue expanding: [the East Link extension opened on March 26, 2026](#), allowing travel across Lake Washington. Other extension projects on Sound Transit are in development, such as the [West Seattle Link Extension](#) to connect West Seattle neighborhoods to light rail. In January 2026, [Seattle added a night bus](#) operating from Seattle-Tacoma International Airport to downtown Seattle, providing 24-hour transit accessibility because light-rail service does not run through the night.
- In 2014, Seattle voters approved funding to improve the [frequency and reach of bus service](#). When the ballot measure passed, only 26% of Seattle households lived within a 10-minute walk of bus service that operated on a frequency of 10 minutes or less. By 2019, bus service improvements meant that [70%](#) of households were within a 10-minute walk of a route that had buses [at least six times an hour](#). However, as of 2023, Seattle had lost ground, as only [52%](#) of households were within a 10-minute walk of a frequent transit stop. The city's goal is to increase the number to [77%](#). Since the COVID-19 pandemic and resultant changes in ridership patterns, Seattle has focused on improving transit service beyond traditional commute hours.
- That 2015 ballot measure also provided funding to make [walking and biking safer and more comfortable](#), such as with [protected bike lanes](#) and more signalized crosswalks. Since then, [64 miles have been added to the bicycle network, and three new bridges have been built for walking and biking](#).

The success of Seattle and Washington state in reducing per capita VMT demonstrates that ever-increasing driving does not have to be our national fate. Policy decisions and changing economic and demographic realities can cause per capita VMT to decline, and transportation planning and investments should reflect that.

Unfortunately, funding cuts for transit and for infrastructure that make walking and biking possible may undermine the progress states have already made and limit future reductions in driving. The Trump administration has proposed reducing transit funding [by 23%](#) for fiscal year 2027 and [cutting \\$1.2 billion](#) from a grant program for transit infrastructure projects, while leaving funding for highways unchanged. In addition, the U.S. Department of Transportation [has indicated](#) that

federal grants to improve street safety – an important source of funding for bike and pedestrian projects – are not likely to be granted to projects that take space away from cars or impede vehicle flow.

At the same time, farebox revenue and state and local funding for transit is not enough to maintain service levels. Transit agencies, including [Bay Area Rapid Transit](#) (in the San Francisco area), [TriMet](#) in Portland, Ore., and [Pittsburgh Regional Transit](#), face multi-million dollar budget shortfalls that may jeopardize the service and infrastructure that make it easier for people to drive less.

Change is possible, and a future of less pollution, better quality of life, and more transportation choices can be ours – if we prioritize the right policies.

** We downloaded [1981-2017](#) per capita VMT data provided by Jeff Davis of the Eno Center for Transportation. We calculated per capita VMT for 2018-2024 using VMT data from the Federal Highway Administration's [Highway Statistics](#) Table VM-2 for the relevant years and state population estimates from the Census Bureau. Population estimates for 2018 and 2019 came from Table NST-EST2019-01, 2021-2022 population estimates came from Table [NST-EST2022-POP](#) (accessed May 4, 2023), 2023-2024 population estimates came from [NST-EST2024-POP](#) (accessed summer 2025), and 2025 population estimates came from Table [NST-EST2025-POP](#) (accessed June 6, 2026).*

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